

The Medium Is Changing the Mind: AI and the Restructuring of Cognition

Reality Drift Failure Modes Series | 02 Externalized Recursion Instability

A. Jacobs — Reality Drift Framework

Core Claim

Cognition is not fixed. It is shaped by the systems used to represent, store, and process information. As those systems change, so does the structure of thought itself.

The Pattern

Human cognition has always evolved alongside its representational tools. Each major shift in representation has reorganized how we perceive, store, and relate to reality. Speech externalized coordination. Writing stabilized language outside the mind. Print scaled and standardized knowledge.

What feels new about the present moment is the speed at which it is unfolding. The same dynamic that once played out over centuries is now compressing into years as digital environments and AI reshape language, attention, and thought in real time.

AI introduces a system that does not just store or transmit language, but actively generates, transforms, and feeds it back into the cognitive process. The medium is no longer passive, but participative. Seen this way, we are living through a cognitive transition, in which the system is changing faster than we can stabilize around it.

The Mechanism

AI changes cognition by altering the relationship between thought, language, and feedback.

Traditionally, most cognitive work occurred within the individual. Ideas were developed internally before being communicated externally. AI introduces a different pattern. Partial thoughts can be externalized immediately, transformed through interaction, and reintroduced into the cognitive process.

As this loop repeats, language becomes more than a tool for expressing thought. It becomes part of how thought is developed. The result is a more recursive form of cognition, where reasoning emerges through ongoing interaction between internal attention and external systems.

Where This Shows Up

In everyday cognition, people increasingly think through systems rather than in isolation. Ideas develop through interaction with tools, while language becomes iterative, co-generated, and shaped through feedback.

This is the condition of co-cognition. Thought developing through continuous interaction between human attention and external cognitive systems. AI mediation changes the loop because the system does not simply return information. It structures the next step of thought.

This weakens the boundary between internal thought and external input. AI systems reflect aggregated human patterns back into individual cognition, creating recursive loops between collective and personal thought.

Reality Drift Connection

Reality Drift describes what happens when systems remain operational while losing alignment with reality. As the medium of cognition changes, the systems shaping thought can drift faster than individuals can stabilize meaning within them. This is especially true when language and reasoning are continuously reshaped by systems optimized for fluency, speed, and engagement.

In this environment, cognition itself becomes more vulnerable to drift. Previous transitions gave people time to adapt. This one is unfolding in real time.

Core Framework and Sources

- [Substack \(Articles\)](#)
- [GitHub \(Full Library\)](#)
- [DOI \(Research Paper\)](#)
- [Glossary & Definition](#)